out by a strategic establishment that suffers terminally from a cold war mindset, and does not quite know, like all bigger powers [the US included], when to declare victory, and when to cut its losses'.[139] There were legal aspects to undertaking arms transfers as well. Indian law did not allow the export of lethal weapons to other countries—one reason why India 'gifted' the four Mi-25 helicopters in 2015.

Compounding this debate on whether, to what extent, of what kind, and when New Delhi should provide lethal weapons to Kabul were India's defence and financial capacity constraints. In 2012, India did not have the finances to either supply weapons or pay for the same to Russia. The government, in fact, was facing a massive resource crunch with extremely high levels of budgetary cuts. 'We did not know where the money would come from for such [armed] support to Afghanistan. We fought tough battles with the ministry of finance, at times with the NSA's support, but it still did not work out', says a senior diplomat.[140] Despite reservations about the political fallout of arming Afghanistan, officials engaged in decision-making, including Menon, contend that there was no deliberate attempt to scuttle the delivery of weapons.[141] In fact, the other option India discussed was to refurbish old Soviet weaponry. But these discussions took longer than expected for bureaucratic reasons. Not all weapons could be refurbished from India, and opening maintenance factories in Afghanistan was too much of a political issue.[142]

Lack of clarity among Afghan officials about the kind of weapons they required and the kind of army they were planning to build compounded this delay. There were several lists that kept changing depending who was asking for the weapons. Bismillah Khan Mohammadi, Afghanistan's defence minister, reached out to Menon seeking one set of weapons whereas other officials had put forth a separate list, confusing the Indian leadership. The ANSF had been trained in using American weaponry whereas the Indian armed forces were still more comfortable with Russian or indigenously produced weapons systems, raising questions about the compatibility of Indian arms in the Afghan army. During one of Karzai's many visits to New Delhi, Menon informed the president that the two countries needed a detailed conversation about what kind of force Kabul wanted to build.[143] Once that was clear, India could tell them what it can do and what it